had started to draft a message ordering the evacuation of Tawang when he was called to the chief's office.

Thapar greeted him with a smile and said: 'Well done, Monty, you handled that well.' Between Palit, Thapar and Niranjan Prasad, the stage had been set for the second half of the debacle, the first already having been enacted at Nam Ka Chu. For the men fighting desperately at Bum-la at that very moment, it was perhaps the greatest let-down.

With Thapar having approved the order to evacuate Tawang, Palit rushed back to the Ops Room in Army HQ, where reports of the fighting in Bum-la had started trickling in. Orders were issued for the immediate withdrawal from Tawang.

Even in their wildest dreams, no Chinese commander could have anticipated that the Indians would fold so easily. Right or wrong, the decision to designate Tawang vital ground was taken a year and a half ago, after which thousands of man hours had been used to build up the garrison, to say nothing of the air effort. How, on the whim of a DMO, the COAS could decide to abandon the place, is indicative of the complete collapse of the decision-making process! A tactical withdrawal is one thing, but to fall back the moment the firing starts can only lead to a debacle. It was unfortunate that those who were best suited to fight, like the machine gunners at Bridge 4 and the Assam Rifles at Dhola, chose to leave the battlefield, betraying the sacrifice of those who decided to fight. No amount of post-war rationalizing can cover up the fact that there was a total collapse of command and control.

Palit, as the commander of 7 Brigade who inducted the formation into NEFA in 1959-60, had seen first-hand the huge logistical obstacles. One of the main reasons he did not want to declare Tawang vital ground at that time was undoubtedly the logistics factor. Yet, despite his entreaties, the Tawang garrison continued to be built up. Tragically, when the time came for the troops to buckle down and fight, Palit fell back on his old prejudices and decried Tawang as a defensive position. His timing could not have been worse. Even as he was briefing the prime minister about the need to withdraw from Tawang, one single company of 1 Sikh at Tenglong-la was valiantly holding back the Chinese.

Palit overlooked some fundamental factors when he bulldozed the shaken Indian government and the army chief into taking a decision that would further help the Chinese. It is one thing for forward observation posts